COUNTER SALES ESSENTIALS

# Counter Sales Essentials — Level 1 — Day 3: Recommending and Adding What the Job Needs

**Study guide · Self-study**

Level 1 · Day 3: Recommending and Adding What the Job Needs

## How to Use This Guide

You already know how a counter sale runs and how to open one well. Today you turn what you heard into a recommendation the customer can act on. You will present one or two clear options, match the item to the job, offer add-ons that make sense, handle an item that is out of stock, and answer a price question with confidence.

Read one section at a time. Do the short writing tasks where they appear. Do not skip to the model answers: write your own words first, then compare. The model answers are examples, not scripts. Your wording should sound like you.

You do not need a counter job to practice. Every task below works with a friend, a phone recording, or a fictional customer written into the guide. If you do work at a counter, use your own customers, but never real names, account details or personal data.

This guide takes about one sitting. Keep a pen and a page nearby.

## Today's Objectives (KASU)

Knowledge: You will know how to present one or two clear options in the customer's own terms, how good-better-best helps only when it fits the job, what makes an add-on honest, and how to answer price and out-of-stock questions without overpromising.

Attitude: You will shift from showing everything you know to giving the customer the right thing the first time, and you will treat an unneeded add-on as a cost to your next visit, not a win.

Skill: You will be able to build a two-option recommendation for a real or fictional counter customer, phrase an add-on as a question about the job, offer a clear substitute or order time, and answer a price question in one calm sentence.

Upskill: You will be able to handle an out-of-stock item and a price question in one calm exchange: a real substitute or an order with a day you can keep, then a plain price followed by a pause.

The First-Contact Standard you learned on Day 2 still opens every counter conversation. Today picks up after it: the moment you know what the customer is trying to do.

## Present One or Two Options, in the Customer's Terms

Here is the mistake most new counter sellers make. They know a lot, so they show it: every model, every size, every brand on the shelf. The customer leaves confused and buys nothing.

Think about why. A counter customer arrives with a task, not a hobby. They want to get back to the job. Every extra option is one more thing to weigh, and weighing costs effort. When the list grows, the customer does not feel served; they feel asked to do your job. Research on choice overload found that a wider assortment can reduce buying rather than increase it (Iyengar & Lepper, 2000). At a counter, the cost is worse: a long queue is listening to every word, and a confused customer often steps aside "to think."

So narrow first. After you know the job, offer one clear recommendation, or two at most, and name them in the customer's language. Not "the 18-volt brushless with the two-speed gearbox." Say "this one is for the job you described, and it will still be running when the job is done."

Two options work when the customer has a real choice to make: this size or that, the budget one or the tougher one. One option works when the answer is obvious. Your recommendation is a service. A customer who came in unsure and leaves with the right item trusts you next time.

Practice example: A customer at a building supply counter says they are fixing a garden fence that blows over each winter. You could list seven post types. Instead you say: "For a fence that takes wind, most people are choosing between these two: the deeper-set post that costs a little more, or the standard one if the posts go into firm ground. Where are you setting the posts?" That is one recommendation with a reason, plus a question that decides it.

Reflect for a moment: the last time someone showed you too many options, what did you actually do? Write a sentence about it. Hold that feeling. That is the customer you are serving.

## Good, Better, Best, Only When It Helps

You have seen three products lined up at a counter: good, better, best. It works because it gives the customer a simple ladder. They see the trade-offs once, choose a rung, and the decision feels quick. It also anchors the conversation: next to the top option, the middle option looks reasonable (Tversky & Kahneman, 1974).

It only helps when three things are true. All three items are real answers to the job. You can say plainly what each one gives. And the price gaps are small enough to compare. If the middle option is the right one for most customers, say so: "Most people with your job take this one."

Use good-better-best when the customer hesitates between quality levels or the job has a lifespan question: will this last one season or ten? Skip it when the answer is obvious or the customer has already chosen. Pushing a ladder nobody needs is the same clutter in a nicer package.

Practice example: A paint counter, fictional products. Good: the standard interior paint at a lower price. Better: the washable version for a hallway. Best: the top coat for a room with heavy traffic and dogs. You say: "This hallway takes a lot of touching, so the washable one is what I would put here. The top one is for when you want it to look new for years." Then ask which room it is.

## Add-Ons: What the Job Really Needs

An add-on is an item the job needs that the customer has not thought of. The filter is simple: the job needs it, not the sale. A customer buying a part that connects to another part needs the connector. A customer buying a phone needs a case if they told you they drop phones. A customer buying a fixture needs the fasteners, because without them the job does not finish.

This is not a pitch; it is finishing the job. The psychology goes one way: a customer who gets home and finds the job stopped for a missing item remembers the gap, not the sale. Worse, they remember who served them. That is why an unneeded add-on costs you the next visit. Trust works like an emotional bank account: kept promises and good judgment are deposits, a letdown is a

withdrawal (Covey, 1989). And bad moments weigh more than good ones of the same size (Baumeister et al., 2001). One pushy add-on can outweigh ten smooth sales.

So phrase the add-on as a question about the job, not a suggestion about your numbers: "Do you have the fasteners for that, or shall I add a pack?" "Are you setting this into concrete or into soil?" The customer answers the job question, and the add-on follows naturally, or it does not. If the answer is "I have them at home," accept and move on.

Watch for the pushy feeling. Rule of thumb: if you cannot finish the sentence "you need this because the job..." with a real reason, do not offer it.

Practice example: A phone counter. You hear "it is for my son, first phone, he is careful but he is twelve." You say: "Most parents of a first phone take the case now rather than after the first drop. Do you want the case with it, or will he be using one you already have?" The reason is real, the question is about their situation, and either answer is fine.

Practice example: A print shop. "You will be folding these, so do you want them scored as well, or are you folding by hand?"

## Out of Stock: Substitute or Order, Without Overpromising

The customer asks for an item you do not have. The instinct is to apologize and let them go. Instead, do two things fast. First, give them a real substitute that does the job. Second, if no substitute works, offer an order with a time you can actually keep.

Honesty is the whole technique. A promise you cannot keep is the worst outcome at a counter: the customer plans their job around it, it fails, and the return visit is not a sale. Bad news has more weight than good news (Baumeister et al., 2001). So say what you know and what you do not. "I can have the exact one here on Thursday morning, and I will call you when it lands" is better than "it should be in soon." If the delivery day is uncertain, say "I can check the delivery time now, and tell you the day I can promise." A customer can plan around a sure thing; they cannot plan around a maybe.

And remember what the customer is really buying: the finished job, back in their hands. If a substitute gets the job done today, most customers take it, because waiting costs them more than a small difference in the item. Explain the difference in one line and let them choose.

Practice example: A customer wants a specific size of fastener that is out. You say: "I am out of that length until Thursday. This one is the same thread and a little longer; if your fixing is not tight to the surface, it does the same job today. If you need the exact length, I can order it for Thursday morning. Which works better for your job?" That is a real choice, told plainly.

## Answering Price Questions With Confidence

When a customer asks "how much is this?", your first job is not to defend the number. It is to answer plainly and let the value land. Say the price, in one calm sentence, and stop. Fast, jittery delivery signals doubt, and customers read the delivery as much as the words; research on vocal confidence shows listeners take cues from how something is said (Guyer, Fabrigar, & Vaughan-Johnston, 2019).

A short pause after the price gives the customer room to think and often to speak. Silent space is not a fight to win.

If the customer reacts, "that seems high," do not rush to features. Connect the number to the job: "It costs more than the budget one, and it is the one that finishes your job without a second trip." Then stop again. Your calm is doing as much work as your sentence.

On Day 4 you will work through price objections and "I'll check somewhere else" with the Mandatory Pause and A.R.T., MEDJAY's own framework for objections and concerns. For today, just train the plain answer and the pause.

## Apply It in Your Role

These are the counter moments where today's skills show up. If you are not at a counter yet, these are exactly the moments an interviewer will ask you about.

When the customer names an item: ask one question about the job before you reach for stock. "What is it going on?" finds the real need and shows you know the difference between a part and a job.

When the customer hesitates between options: offer your recommendation, with the reason, in their words. "This one is for the job you described."

When the job implies a missing item: offer the add-on as a question about the job, and accept no.

When the item is out: offer the substitute with one honest line on the difference, then an order with a day you can keep.

When they ask the price: say it plainly, stop, let them think.

No counter job yet: watch how a real counter handles these moments when you shop. Notice when you bought something extra and why. Notice when you walked away and why.

## What Would You Say?

Write your answer to each before reading the models.

1. A customer asks for "a small tube of sealant" and you have three kinds on the shelf. What do you say?

2. A customer is buying a drill for a one-room job, and the cheapest one will do it. Do you show them anything else? Write what you would say.

3. A customer picks up a faucet. The job also needs a supply line they have not asked about. Write your add-on question.

4. The item they want is out until next week and they need the job done today. Write the substitute or order, in your words.

## Key Takeaways

- Give the right thing the first time; accuracy beats speed.

- Offer one or two clear options, in the customer's language, not a shelf full of choices.
- Use good-better-best only when all three are real answers to the job and the ladder helps the customer decide.
- An add-on is for the job, not for the sale. Phrase it as a question about the job, and accept no.
- An item that is out is a chance to solve the job today, with a substitute or an order with a day you can keep.
- Answer a price in one calm sentence and stop.

# Quiz

Answer all five. Give each a single letter.

1. A customer asks for a specific bearing for a machine repair. You have six versions on the shelf. What is your best move?

   **A.** Ask what the machine is and where the bearing sits, then present one or two that fit.

   **B.** Line all six up on the counter and explain each one.

   **C.** Hand over the cheapest and let them decide.

   **D.** Hand over the most expensive and say it is the best.

2. When does good-better-best work well at the counter?

   **A.** Every time, because the customer likes to see all the levels.

   **B.** Only when you want to move the customer to the top of the ladder.

   **C.** When all three items really answer the job and the customer is choosing a quality level.

   **D.** Only for customers you have never served before.

3. A customer buying a power tool mentions they will use it on ladder work. What is an honest add-on?

   **A.** Add the premium blade and say it is better.

   **B.** Ask if they have a secure way to hold it at height, and offer the strap if they do not.

   **C.** Say the tool will not work without the strap.

   **D.** Add the strap without asking, since it is cheap.

4. The exact item is out until Thursday and the customer wants the job finished today. What do you offer?

   **A.** A different item, and say it is the same.

   **B.** "It should be in soon," so they can come back.

   **C.** A real substitute with one honest line on the difference, or an order with a day you can keep.

   **D.** The exact item from the back room, even if you cannot see it.

5. A customer asks the price of the item you recommended and pulls a face. What is your first move?

   **A.** Start listing the item's features quickly.

   **B.** Offer a discount straight away to keep them.

**C.** Ask them what they expected to pay.

**D.** Say the price plainly, stop, and connect it to the job in one line if they react.

## Upskill Challenge

This is your on-the-job challenge for Day 3. Do it over the next few days. Use a friend or a phone recording if you do not work at a counter.

Task 1: Build a two-option recommendation. Pick a fictional customer and write their job in one line. Then write two options you would present at a counter of your choice: an auto parts counter, hardware, building supply, phone and electronics, paint and tools, a pharmacy-style counter, or a print shop. Each option gets one sentence in the customer's terms and one reason it fits the job.

Task 2: Role-play one add-on. With a friend, or into your phone, play the customer first and then the seller. Offer an add-on as a question about the job. Then play it again and notice the moment it starts to feel pushy. Write down what made the difference.

Task 3: Role-play out of stock. Take task 1's item and make it out of stock until a day you choose. Record twenty seconds of yourself offering a substitute or an order with a day you can keep. Listen back once and check that every promise is one you could hold.

Task 4: Practice on your phone. Record yourself answering "I'll check somewhere else" across the counter. Say what you would say today, in your own words, then save the recording. On Day 4 you will learn a method for this and hear the difference in your own voice.

Here is the format to write task 1 in:

Fictional customer:

Job in one line:

Option one:

Why it fits:

Option two:

Why it fits:

> **NOTES**
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> If the add-on in task 2 felt pushy, that is useful information, not failure. Notice the exact sentence that felt wrong, and rewrite it as a question about the job.

## Model Answers

These are examples. Your words should sound like you.

1. "Sure. What are you sealing, and is the surface moving or still?" Then: "For a still joint like that, this one is the right grade. If the joint moves, take this one instead." Why it works: one question finds the job, and one or two items follow.

2. "For a one-room job, the cheapest one here does what you need. The next one up lasts longer if you will use it again next year. Will this be a one-off?" Why it works: honesty about the job builds trust, and the second option appears only as a real choice.

3. "Do you have the supply lines for this, or shall I add a pair?" Why it works: it is a question about the job, not about your numbers, and the customer can answer either way.

4. "I am out of the exact one until Thursday. This one is the same fitting and a little heavier; if your setup has room for that, it finishes the job today. If you need the exact fit, I will order it for Thursday morning. Which works better for you?" Why it works: a real substitute, one honest difference, and an order with a day you can keep.

Now read your own answers again. Where your wording differs from these, keep yours if it names the job and lets the customer choose.

Quiz answers:

1. A. Finding the job first lets you present one or two items that fit, which is what keeps the customer from freezing over six choices.

2. C. Good-better-best only helps when every rung is a real answer to the job and the customer has a genuine quality choice.

3. B. The add-on is phrased as a question about the job, and the customer can say no.

4. C. A real substitute or an order with a day you can keep moves the job forward without a promise you cannot hold.

5. D. The plain price and a calm pause show confidence and give the customer room to think.

# References

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